

|
COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM |NEW STATE RECORD X UNUSUAL RECORD _____**Species:** Smith's Longspur (*Calcarius pictus*)**Date:** 11 September 2002 **Number seen:** two **Sex:** ? **Plumage:** First Basic (?)**Locality:** Barr Lake**Elevation:** ~5000'**Nearest town:** Brighton**County:** Adams**Time observed:** ~08:00 - 08:45**Duration of observation:** about 1.5 minutes in that span in three encounters

Description: I was perusing the shorebirds in the southeastern part of Barr Lake, when I heard and saw a flock of Horned Larks (HOLA) come in from behind me (from the east) and land on the beach near the water's edge only about 8-12 meters to the south of me. Since they were so close and I could get my scope on them, I decided to look for something outlandish among them, e.g., Sprague's Pipit or Yellow Wagtail. I had just started sorting through them when I noted a sparrow-like bird that, on first impression, I thought might be a Vesper Sparrow (white in the outer tail, black-centered tertials, and white eye ring). However, I quickly realized upon noticing the very long primary projection that the bird was no sparrow, but a longspur. I then started to hold my breath, as the features that I was ticking off suggested to me that the bird was a Smith's Longspur (SMLO). I continued through the remainder of the flock of ~20 birds and noted a second individual longspur, that was a bit closer to me than the first one, so I studied that one. It looked, in most regards, very much like the first bird, though possibly with a stronger face pattern. The bird was very nearly full-frame in my scope and I studied the bird hard and took copious mental notes. The entire flock spent most of the time I was looking at the birds on alert, and after about a minute, the flock departed, sweeping out over the water, back over my head, and then headed north up the beach, during which time the longspur(s) called.

Shortly thereafter, I saw Glenn Walbek and Loch Kilpatrick to the north and, hoping that they had seen, or at least heard, the birds informed them of the longspurs. They had not noted the longspurs, but they started looking hard for them. At one point, at least part of the flock flew over and I again heard at least one of the longspurs give its typical rattle call. A bit later, when I was again by myself, I saw and heard the longspurs flying over with about seven HOLAs. I later ran into Doug Faulkner, whom I had informed of the presence of the birds, and he had seen and heard them, but also just flying over. When I returned to the office at about 10:00, I wrote extensive notes on the birds without reference to identification material.

The two birds were similar enough that I here describe them as one, noting where the two birds differed. The overall impression that the bird gave me was of buff - the entire underparts were buff, as was much of the facial pattern. The bill was pale with a dark culmen, the eyes were dark, surrounded by thin, but obvious white rings. The buff superciliary had faint dark streaks in it. There was no dark eyeline before the eye, but

there was behind the eye and it formed the top edge of a dark auriculars surround (that was a bit more obvious on one bird), which was broken on the posterior edge by a bright buff patch. The malar (sensu Sibley 2003) was buff, paler than the underparts, and was bordered by a thin, brownish lateral throat stripe.

The back and rump were a mixture of brown and buff, but I did not study these carefully. The buff chest had indistinct brownish streaking that extended down the sides nearly to the flanks; the belly was unstreaked.

The wings were darker than any other part of the body, possibly because the tertials were black with rufous leading edges, without the strong intrusion of rufous into the centers typical of Lapland Longspurs (LALO). The greater coverts had thin, white tips forming a vague wingbar but the median coverts had thicker white tips forming an obvious wingbar when the scapulars were not covering them. But, as the birds were on alert so much of the time, the second wingbar was obvious. The most illuminating feature on the wing, however, was the primary tips - the longest primary projected beyond the largest tertial a length almost equivalent to the length of the longest tertial. Additionally, I could easily discern a very large gap in spacing between the two longest primaries and the next shortest primary visible on the folded wing, which was followed by a smaller gap and then two or three minuscule gaps. Oddly, I did not note leg color.

When the bird was in flight, I once saw a hint of white in the lesser coverts on one of the birds, though the view was very brief. I did not note the color of the underside of the wings, though it would have been easy had I paid attention to that feature when the birds twice flew over my head. From underneath, the tail looked almost entirely white, with a thin, dark strip down the middle - the part of the tail not obstructed by the white outer rectrices. The bird's tail did not have the black terminal triangle typical of Chestnut-collared (CCLO) and McCown's (MCLO) longspurs, nor the more extensive dark base and center line typical of LALO.

Similar species eliminated: CCLO and MCLO both eliminated on tail pattern, tertial pattern, call note, and primary projection. LALO ruled out by underparts coloration and pattern, tertial pattern, head pattern, and call note. Virtually all sparrows eliminated by primary projection, as well as by numerous plumage features.

Describe the bird's song and call, if given, including method of delivery (i.e. from perch, in flight, duration): About six times, I heard the bird give the long rattle typical of SMLO and LALO and not typical of MCLO; CCLO does not have a rattle call. Though I have never previously heard SMLO before, I have heard LALO hundreds of times and the rattle that these birds gave was longer and of a different quality than typical of LALO. The call consisted of some six or seven notes; in my experience, LALO's rattle is a note or two shorter.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly-appearing species? I have seen 1000s and 1000s of LALO, and 1000s of both CCLO and MCLO; I may have seen SMLO once before (a chased bird in AL), but I am no longer convinced that the ID was correct.

Light conditions: sun to my left and behind partly overcast skies

Optical equipment used: Leica 20x-60x

Distance, and how estimated: estimated closest distance at about eight meters

Other observers who saw the bird with you: none, sort of, though Glenn Walbek and Loch Kilpatrick both heard them with me

Other observers who saw the bird independently: Doug Faulkner, sort of

If photographed, type of equipment and film: I did not photograph the bird, though had I had my digital camera with me, I could have absolutely hammered them.

List books, illustrations, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

a) at time of observation: none
none

b) after



observation:

Reporting observer: Tony Leukering

Signature:

Address: Rocky Mountain Bird Observatory, 14500 Lark Bunting Lane, Brighton, CO 80603

Date report was written: Written on 16 September 2002 and 21 August 2003 from extensive notes written less than two hours after the sighting

Literature Cited:

Sibley, D.A. 2003. The Sibley Field Guide to Birds of Western North America. Alfred A. Knopf, Inc. New York.